

Gamification in Education

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1 Introduction

Once, we learned for knowledge.

Then came the points.

Then the badges.

Then the leaderboards.

And suddenly, education was no longer about learning.

It was about XP.

Gamification has become prevalent in the educational space as an engagement strategy and to incentivize learners. Points, badges and levels are just some examples of the gamified concepts used to encourage and motivate students. Ester, however, has never been a fan of gamification. Having worked both in school and as a private tutor, Ester has witnessed first hand how gamification can deeply impact the learning experience. Her father is a teacher and often speaks of different methodologies used to engage students.

Today, Ester works as a consultant for a company that develops Salesforce CRM solutions. She has always been a self-learner, kind and patient with others, but stubborn about being told how to study. When her employer began forcing her to acquire the Salesforce Administrator certification, she took the pressure seriously and worked hard, but the badges and points built into the learning platform never motivated her in the intended way. If anything, it made a subject she held in high regard feel like an elaborate farce. Gamification is therefore no longer confined to games, but rather is a part of education, personal growth and learning. But does gamification actually improve learning, or rather just make education more engaging? Reviewing the field reveals that gamification does have cognitive, as well as emotional and behavioural positive overall effects, but that the quality of gamification as well as the particular game elements used is of equal importance [1].

2 The Battle of the Gamers

Ester is sitting at home, the room lit only by the pale glow of her laptop screen. On the desk beside her, a can of soda has gone flat, forgotten somewhere between

the third and fourth round. The notification sound plays again, a short bright chime, the same chime that plays every time someone's name moves. She has learned to tell the difference between the chime that means someone climbed and the one that means someone fell, though the sound itself never changes, only her stomach does. On the screen, a leaderboard refreshes itself in real time. Names rearrange, numbers tick upward in green, small animated stars burst beside whoever sits at the top. Her own name sits near the bottom, grey against all that shine, and no matter how quickly she answers, no matter how many rounds she plays, it barely moves. Downstairs, her mother calls up to ask how she is doing, and Ester calls back down that she is doing great, her voice coming out brighter and steadier than she actually feels, the lie smoother than she expected it to be. Her palms are damp against the trackpad. Her jaw aches from smiling at a screen no one else can see. Every few minutes a new round begins, and the timer counts down in the corner, red numbers shrinking second by second, and her hand hovers over the keys, already bracing for the small drop her name will take before the numbers even land.

Somewhere close to midnight the chime rings one more time and Ester does not hear it. Her head has come to rest against her forearm, the cursor blinking uselessly in an empty answer field, and the room around her dissolves the way rooms do in sleep: quietly, without a single seam to mark where waking ends. She opens her eyes onto a stadium she has never been to, tiered seats rising into a sky the exact yellow of a Salesforce onboarding screen, and she knows, the way you sometimes know things in dreams without being told, that she is dreaming, and that this particular dream is not going to let her go until she has earned it.

Astro is waiting for her at the centre of the field. Not the small plush toy from the trade show booths, but life sized, a raccoon zipped inside its own furred hood, round black eyes catching no light at all. Its voice, when it speaks, is warm in the practiced way customer service is warm.

Ahead of her, where the field should keep going, there is a wall instead: tall, smooth, built out of something that looks almost like frosted glass, the kind Ester has stared through on a hundred loading screens without ever being able to see what was on the other side. Astro gestures toward it and waits, patient in the way only something built to wait can be.

"Hey there Ester! It's me Astro! And welcome to the stadium! Now if you argue well, then the wall comes down and you move on to the next level! YAY!!! Fail to convince me, and you stay right here! Best of luck!"

Ester does not move yet. She is still staring up at the wall, still working out what argument she is even going to need, and for now that is where the dream leaves her: standing on the grass of a stadium built out of onboarding screens, one unbroken wall ahead of her, and an AI raccoon waiting patiently for her to begin.

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